

ART & CULTURE



PUPPETRY & MARTIAL ARTS

MODULE - 2

MARTIAL ARTS

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

INTRODUCTION



1 India, the land of diverse culture and ethnicities, is known for its **wide variety of martial arts** that have developed since the ancient times.

2 Earlier used for **warfare**, these art forms are today **used for demonstration**, as a part of a ritual, achieving physical fitness or as a means of self-defense.

3 Martial art literally means ‘arts associated with the **waging of war**’.

4 A number of martial arts in the country are closely related to **dance, yoga and performing arts**.

5 Some of the art forms were banned during the British rule, including Kalaripayattu and Silambam, but they resurfaced and gained popularity post independence.



**Silambam - An integral part of
Tamil culture**

1

SILAMBAM

SILAMBAM AND ITS HISTORIC ORIGINS



Silambam was employed by the warrior queen Velu Nachiyar, who fought against the British long before the legendary Rani of Jhansi.

1

Silambam, a kind of **staff fencing**, is a modern and scientific martial art of Tamil Nadu.

2

The kings that ruled in Tamil Nadu, including Pandya, Chola, and Chera, had promoted it during their reign.

3

The **reference to the sale of Silambam staff**, pearls, swords and armour to foreign traders can be seen in a Tamil literature known as Silapaddigaram.

1

SILAMBAM

SILAMBAM AND ITS HISTORIC ORIGINS



- 4 The silambam staff was one of the most popular trading item with the traders and visitors from Rome, Greece and Egypt.
- 5 This art is believed to have travelled to Malaysia from its originating state, where it is a famous sport apart from being a mode of self-defence.
- 6 The long-staff was used for both mock fighting and self-defence.
- 7 This was one of the highly organized and popular games of the state since the first century A.D.

1 SILAMBAM

SILAMBAM AND ITS HISTORIC ORIGINS



The different weaponry used in Silambam

8 The record of its origin can be traced to divine sources, for example Lord **Muruga** (in Tamil mythology) and sage **Agasthya** are credited with the creation of Silambam.

9 During the **Vedic age**, training was imparted to young men as a ritual and for an emergency.

10 From a pure defense art, **Silambam** has transformed into a combat exercise.

11 There are different kinds of staff used in this art.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

1

SILAMBAM

VARIOUS ETIQUETTES OF SILAMBAM



12

- The first, called 'torch silambam', has lighted balls of cloth at one end of the staves,
- second produces a sonorous swishing sound,
- the third is a non-elastic staff that gives clattering sounds etc.

13

As far as the dress is concerned, the players wear langots of different colors, turbans, sleeveless vests, and chest guard and use wickerwork shields.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

1

SILAMBAM

DIFFERENT TECHNIQUES OF SILAMBAM



Various staff used in Silambam

14 There are different kinds of techniques that are use in Silambam including swift movements of the foot, use of both hands to wield staff, use of thrust, cut, chop and sweep to achieve mastery and development of force, momentum and precision at different levels of the body.

15 The player must be trained to diffuse an uncontrollable mob by using strokes like snake hits, monkey hits, hawk hits and also deflect stones thrown by them.

1

SILAMBAM

WAYS TO WIN IN SILAMBAM!!!



16 There are three ways to win in Silambam contest.

17 The first involves **dispossessing** a **player** of his **staff**.

18 The second requires **counting** of the **number** of **'touches'** (that are indicated by the number of markings on the body of the opponent) made by one contestant on the other.

19 The third is **by judging** the **skill** shown by **each** **contestant** in **protecting** **money pouch** that is either kept at or between contestant's feet.

20 Also, the contestant who succeeds in **marking** the **forehead** of his **opponent** wins the contest.

2

KUTTU VARISAI



- 1 First mentioned in Sangam literature (first or second century B.C.), **kuttu Varisari** translates to 'empty hand combat'.

- 2 Kuttu Varisai is mainly practiced in South India, although it is quite popular in **north-eastern part of Sri Lankan and Malaysia** too.

- 3 An unarmed Dravidian martial art, it is used to **advance athleticism and footwork through yoga, gymnastics and breathing exercises.**

- 4 The major techniques used in this art include **grappling, striking and locking.**

- 5 It also uses **animal based techniques** including those of snake, eagle, tiger, elephant and monkey.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

3

KALARIPAYATTU



- 1 One of the oldest martial arts in India, Kalaripayattu, although practiced in most parts of southern India, originated in the state of **Kerala** in the 4th century A.D.
- 2 Kalari, a Malayalam word, refers to a specific type of school/ gymnasium/ training hall where martial arts are practiced or taught.
- 3 According to legends, sage **Parasurama** started Kalaripayattu.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

3

KALARIPAYATTU

4 This art form includes mock duels (armed and unarmed combat) and physical exercises.

5 Not accompanied by any drumming or song, the most important aspect is the style of fighting.



6 Kalaripayattu's most important key is foot work; it also includes kicks, strikes and weapon-based practice.



*“Defying age with a sword” :
Meenakshi Gurrukkal, Kerala's
grand old Kalaripayattu dame*

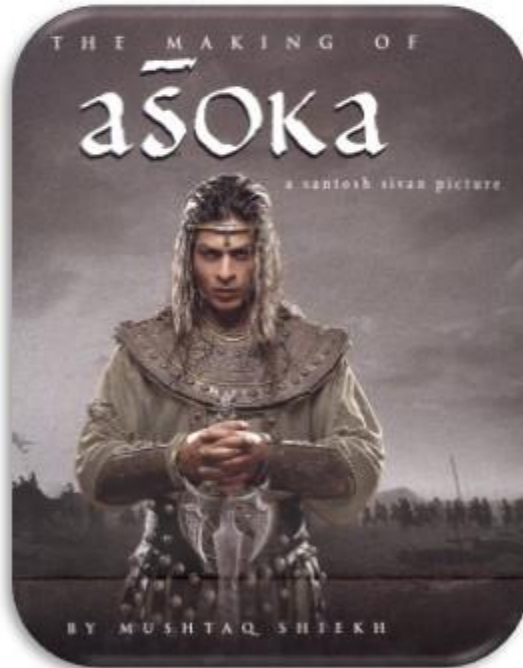
MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

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KALARIPAYATTU

7

Its popularity in the country can be easily seen when one looks at **Indian movies** including **Ashoka** and **The Myth**.



8

Women practice this art too. Unniyarcha, a legendary heroine, won many battles using this martial art.



3 KALARIPAYATTU

- 9 Even though Kalaripayattu is used as a means of self-defence and a way to achieve physical fitness today, it is still rooted in the traditional rituals and ceremonies.



Uzhichil, a form of oil massage

- 10 Kalaripayattu includes a number of techniques and aspects.

- 11 Some of the techniques are:
- Uzhichil - oil massage
 - Otta - an S-shaped staff
 - Maipayattu - Body exercises
 - Puliyanam - sword fight,
 - Verumkai - bare-handed fight,
 - AngaThari - use of metal weapons
 - Kolthari - use of wooden sticks

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

KALARIPAYATTU

Some of the techniques are:

1 UZHICHIL

Uzhichil, or the massage with the Gingili oil, is used for imparting suppleness to the body, but only persons with a thorough knowledge of the nervous system, and the human body, conduct the 'uzhichil'.

2 OTTA

The Otta is an 'S' shaped staff, with a knob at one end, made of the toughest portions of the tamarind tree. These sticks, which are about 2 feet long, are specially suitable for attacks on the nervous system.

3 MAIPAYATTU

Body exercises or Maippayattu includes the twists and turns of the body, leaps and jumps, and poses, designed to gain control over various parts of the human.



Maipayattu

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KALARIPAYATTU

Some of them are:

4

PULIYANKAM

- Wielding the sword in an efficient manner, is considered to be the **peak of perfection** in Kalari Payattu.
- Various methods in the use of the sword, as a weapon of offence and defense, are being practiced today.
- But the most awe-inspiring of these, is the **Puliyankam**, where the combatants fight like tigers.

5

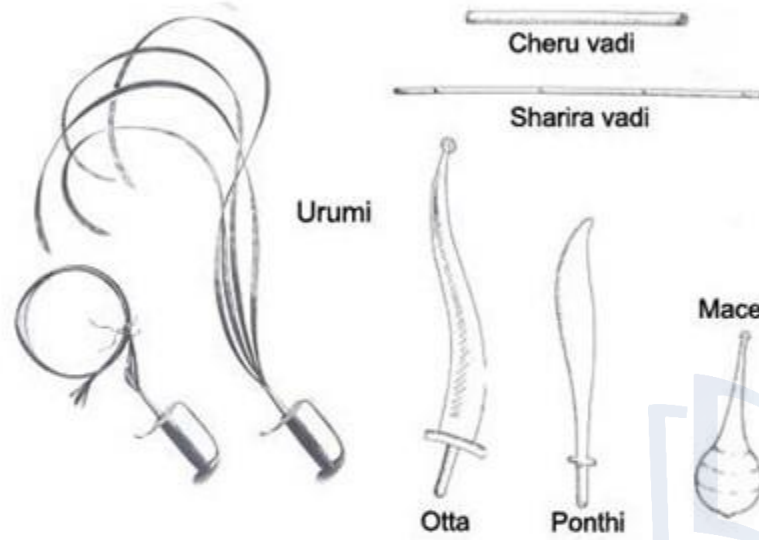
VERUMKAI

- In unguarded moments, there are some special ways of getting out of a tight situation, by using one's hands.
- Locks and blows are in vogue.
- **Attacks on the nervous system** by the edge of one's palm, are enough to paralyse the opponent

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

KALARIPAYATTU

Some of the techniques are:



6

ANGATHARI

Weapons of various metals are used in training and combat sessions, like the sword, shield, two types of knives, daggers, the spear and the 'urumi'. Various exercises are performed with these weapons.

7

STICKS OF KOLTHARI

Here training in handling various staves of wood or canes of different lengths are imparted.



Urumi on the left, and various other weaponry in Kalaripayattu

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

4

THANG-TA & SARIT SARAK



- 1 Created by the Meitei people of Manipur, Thang-ta is an armed martial art that finds its mention in the most lethal combat forms.
- 2 Sarit Sarak, on the other hand, is an unarmed art forms that uses hand-to-hand combat.
- 3 Their history can be tracked back to the 17th century when it was used successfully by the Manipur kings to fight the British for quite sometime.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

4

THANG-TA & SARIT SARAK



4 The capture of this region by the British witnessed the ban on these art forms, however post independence there was a resurfacing of the same.

5

Thang refers to a 'sword', while Ta refers to a 'spear', thus sword and spear are the two main elements of Thang-ta.

6

An important variant of this is HuyenLallong, which uses other weapons including an axe and a shield.

7

Thang-Ta is practiced in three different ways.

8

The first is completely ritualistic in nature, linked with tantric practices.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

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THANG-TA & SARIT SARAK



Where Thang ta is armed fighting, Sarit Sarak is unarmed combat

9

The second consists of a mesmerizing performance of spear and sword dances.

10

The third and last involves actual techniques of fighting.

11

Distinct from other martial arts forms, Sarit Sarak is an unarmed combat.

12

When compared to any other existing art forms of the same school, it is quite flawless for its offensive and evasive action.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

5 CHEIBI GAD-GA



1 One of the most ancient martial arts of Manipur, Cheibi Gad-ga involves fighting using a sword and a shield.

2 It has now been modified to a stick encased in soft leather in place of a sword and leather shield.

3 The contest takes place in a circle of 7 metre diameter, on a flat surface.

4 Within the circle, there are two lines, 2 metre apart. The 'Cheibi' stick is between 2 to 2.5 feet in length, while the shield is around 1 metre in diameter.

5 Victory in this contest achieved according to the points earned during a duel. The points are given based on skills displayed by the contestant.

MARTIAL ARTS IN INDIA

6

PARI-KHANDA



1 Pari-khanda is a form of martial art from Bihar.

2 It involves fighting using sword and shield.

3 Still practiced in many parts of Bihar, its steps and techniques are widely used in Chhau dance.

4 In fact this martial art forms the basis of Chhau dance in which all its elements are absorbed.

5 The name of this martial art consists of two words, 'Pari' that means shield while 'khanda' refers to sword, thus the use of both sword and shield in this art.

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